

ENGLISH LANGUAGE

MODERN ENGLISH (891)

PAPER 1 (Theory)

Maximum Marks: 80

Time Allowed: Three Hours

Reading Time: Additional Fifteen Minutes

Instructions to Candidates

1. You are allowed an additional **fifteen minutes** for **only** reading the question paper.
2. You must **NOT** start writing during reading time.
3. This question paper has 5 printed pages.
4. It has **four** questions in all.
5. Answer **all** questions.
6. You are advised to spend not more than 45 minutes on Question 1, 55 minutes on Question 2, 30 minutes on Question 3 and 50 minutes on Question 4.
7. While answering Multiple Choice Questions in Question 4, you are required to write only **one** option as the answer.
8. You should begin each answer on a fresh page.
9. The intended marks for questions are given in brackets [].

Instruction to Supervising Examiner

1. Kindly read aloud the Instructions given on page 1 to all the candidates present in the examination hall.

Question 1

Write a composition (in approximately 400 – 450 words) on any **one** of the following subjects.
(You are reminded that you will be rewarded for the orderly and coherent presentation of [20] the matter, use of appropriate style and general accuracy of spelling, punctuation and grammar.)

- (i) You recently visited a crowded book fair for the first time. Describe the stalls, the sights and sounds around you, the smell of new and old books, and a writer you met there. Describe how you felt as you left the fair.
- (ii) Your younger cousin went missing at a crowded mela while he was in your care. Narrate how you searched for him and found him, and what the experience taught you about responsibility.
- (iii) Artificial Intelligence tools do students more harm than good. Argue either FOR or AGAINST the given statement.
- (iv) Courage.
- (v) Actions speak louder than words. Present your reflections on this statement.
- (vi) Write an original short story that ends with the words: ‘...and for the first time in years, the old house was filled with laughter.’

Question 2

- (i) Your school magazine is starting a section called 'Books That Stayed With Me'. Write a review of a novel you have read recently, in about 250 – 300 words, based on the following guidelines: [15]
- title, author and genre of the book – its setting and main characters – an outline of the plot, without revealing the ending – the themes it explores – the writing style and a scene you liked – your rating and recommendation to readers
- (ii) As President of the Student Council of your school, you wish to set up a Reading Club and revive the neglected reading corner of the school library. Write a proposal in not more than 150 words, stating the steps you would take to make it a success. [10]

Question 3

Answer subparts (i), (ii) and (iii).

- (i) Rewrite the following sentences according to the instructions given after each of them in brackets. Make other changes that may be necessary, but do not change the meaning of each sentence. [5]
- (a) As soon as the referee blew the final whistle, the spectators rushed onto the field.
(Begin: No sooner ...)
- (b) The village carpenter repaired the broken benches of the old library.
(End: ... the village carpenter.)
- (c) The manager said to the clerk, "Did you post the letters yesterday?"
(Begin: The manager asked ...)
- (d) The carton was too heavy for the delivery boy to lift.
(Use: so ... that)
- (e) Priya is the most patient nurse in the ward.
(Begin: No other ...)
- (ii) Replace the INCORRECT underlined words to make the following sentences meaningful and grammatically correct. Do not copy the sentences. [5]
- (a) Grandmother asked me to look into my little brother while she went to the market.
- (b) The police have promised to look after the complaints of the shopkeepers.
- (c) Despite the heavy rain, the band carried out playing until the last song.
- (d) The soldiers carried on their commander's orders without a moment's hesitation.
- (e) The old bus broke up halfway up the hill, and we had to walk the rest of the way.
- (f) Thieves broke down the jeweller's shop during the festival holidays.
- (g) While clearing the attic, I came over a bundle of my father's school reports.
- (h) After a long discussion, the committee came up to a practical solution.
- (i) The shy boy at the back of the class turned off to be its best singer.
- (j) She turned out the offer because the college was too far from home.

- (iii) Fill in the blanks in the passage given below with the appropriate form of the verb given in brackets. Do not write the passage but write the verbs in the correct order. [5]

Long ago, a proud king _____ (1) (ride) out of his capital at the head of a hundred soldiers. At the city gate an old beggar _____ (2) (sit) under a banyan tree, calmly _____ (3) (eat) a piece of dry bread. The king, who in all his life _____ (4) (see) no one ignore him, stopped his horse and demanded to know why the man did not rise.

“Why should I?” the beggar replied. “You _____ (5) (want) gold, land and glory, and you will never have enough of them. I want nothing, so I am already content.”

The king laughed, but the words stayed with him. For weeks he could not stop _____ (6) (think) about them. At last he returned to the tree, _____ (7) (dress) in plain clothes, and begged the old man to _____ (8) (teach) him the secret of contentment. The beggar simply broke his bread and handed him half. The king _____ (9) (eat) it in silence, and for the first time in many years he _____ (10) (feel) at peace.

Question 4

Read the passage given below and answer the questions (i), (ii) and (iii) that follow.

(1) When Mrs Mehta from the flat opposite asked me to look after her parrot for the weekend, I agreed at once. She was going to her sister’s wedding in Pune, the bird needed only seeds, water and a little conversation, and she offered me two hundred rupees for my trouble. It seemed to me the easiest money a boy of sixteen had ever earned. 5

(2) The parrot was called Brigadier. He was a large green bird with a red collar, a hooked beak and the fixed, disapproving stare of a retired officer inspecting a badly made bed. Mrs Mehta handed me his cage, a bag of sunflower seeds and a typed list of instructions. “He talks,” she warned me at the door, “but do not believe everything he says.” I laughed politely. I did not yet understand that it was the most useful sentence I would hear all weekend. 10

(3) On Saturday morning I carried the cage out onto our balcony so that Brigadier could enjoy the sun. He enjoyed it in silence for an hour. Then, just as I had settled down with my chemistry textbook, a voice behind me said, quite distinctly, “Open the door, please.” It was my mother’s voice, perfectly copied. I jumped up and opened the front door. There was nobody there. Behind me Brigadier made a low, gurgling noise that I can only describe as a chuckle. 15

(4) He did it four more times before lunch, using my mother’s voice, then the milkman’s, and once, horribly, my own. By the afternoon I had stopped jumping up, which was exactly the mistake he had been waiting for. When I came back from the kitchen with his water bowl, the little wire door of the cage was hanging open, and Brigadier was sitting on the railing of the balcony, cleaning his claws. 20

(5) I understood then why one line of the instructions had been typed in capital letters: NEVER LEAVE THE CAGE DOOR UNLATCHED. HE CAN LIFT IT WITH HIS BEAK. 25

(6) I moved towards him very slowly, holding out a sunflower seed and making the soft clicking sound Mrs Mehta had used. Brigadier watched me with interest, waited until my fingers were an inch from his feet, and then stepped neatly off the railing

and flew to the mango tree in the middle of the park.

(7) What followed was the longest afternoon of my life. I ran down four floors and across the park, still holding the seed. I borrowed a ladder from the watchman, climbed halfway up the tree and was greeted by a cheerful whistle from a branch that no ladder could reach. I tried calling him in Mrs Mehta's voice, which I could not do, and in my mother's, which I did even worse. A crowd of small children gathered below to give advice, most of it contradictory and all of it loud. 30 35

(8) At five o'clock I sat down at the foot of the tree, defeated. I was already composing, in my head, the letter of apology I would have to write, when the watchman's little daughter tugged at my sleeve. She pointed out that the bird had been watching my bag of seeds, not me, the whole afternoon. Then she took the bag, poured a small heap of seeds onto the top of the empty cage, and walked away, dragging me with her. 40

(9) We waited behind the hedge. For ten minutes nothing happened. Then, with a rush of green wings, Brigadier came down, landed on the cage and began to eat as though nothing in the world had happened. I crept up behind him, and this time, for once, he was too busy to notice. The door closed with a click that sounded to me like the finest music ever composed. 45

(10) When Mrs Mehta returned on Sunday evening, Brigadier was sitting quietly on his perch, the very picture of good behaviour. She asked me whether he had given any trouble. Before I could answer, a voice from the cage said, in my own tone of exhausted politeness, "No trouble at all, Aunty." Mrs Mehta looked at the bird, then at me, and smiled the smile of someone who has heard that sentence many times before. 50

(11) I did not take the two hundred rupees. I gave them to the watchman's daughter, who had earned every one of them.

(Adapted from: The Brigadier's Weekend, an original story written for this sample paper)

(i)(a) Find a single word from the passage that will exactly replace the underlined word or words in the following sentences. [3]

(1) The child imitated her elder sister's handwriting so well that even their mother was deceived.

(2) The two witnesses gave inconsistent and opposing accounts of the accident.

(3) She spent the whole evening putting together a poem for her mother's birthday.

- (b) For each of the words given below, choose the correct sentence that uses the same word unchanged in spelling, but with a different meaning from that which it carries in the passage. [3]
- (1) **bed** (line 8)
- (A) The river bed was completely dry by the middle of May.
 - (B) The patient was confined to bed for a week.
 - (C) The gardener bedded the young seedlings in fresh soil.
 - (D) He made his bed neatly before breakfast.
- (2) **perch** (line 48)
- (A) The canary hopped back onto its perch and began to sing.
 - (B) The children perched on the wall to watch the procession.
 - (C) The fisherman caught a large perch in the lake.
 - (D) The parrot's perch was a smooth wooden rod.
- (3) **tone** (line 49)
- (A) She answered the question in a gentle tone.
 - (B) Regular swimming improves muscle tone.
 - (C) The music was toned down for the ceremony.
 - (D) The teacher's tone made it clear she was annoyed.
- (ii) Answer the following questions as briefly as possible in your own words.
- (a) Why did the narrator agree so readily to look after Brigadier? [2]
 - (b) Cite two instances from the passage which show that Brigadier was cleverer than the narrator. [2]
 - (c) With reference to the passage, explain the meaning of the expression 'smiled the smile of someone who has heard that sentence many times before'. [2]
- (iii) Summarise how Brigadier escaped and how he was finally caught (paragraphs 4 to 9). You are required to write the summary in the **grid form** in about 100 words. The use of abbreviations and contractions will not be accepted. Failure to keep within the word limit will be penalised. [8]

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